

Engaging Your Audience through Delivery and Structure

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Do you want to build momentum for your ideas and increase the likelihood that your audience will embrace your message? By focusing on your delivery and structure, you can enhance the audience's engagement and involvement with your content.

As you prepare for any business communication, keep the following two things in mind:

1. Delivery – 90% is not what you say, but how you say it (in person & remote)
2. Audience & Structure – a message that highlights what your audience cares about and uses explicit structure is more likely to be remembered (HOP-T)

1. Delivery – 90% is not what you say, but how you say it (in person & remote)

Research shows that the impact a speaker has on an audience is 90% delivery (verbal & non-verbal behaviors) and 10% content. This statistic doesn't mean that content isn't important, but rather that **if the delivery and the content are out of sync, it's the delivery that matters**. A speaker's overall impression is comprised of three elements: **Authority** (posture, stance, gestures), **Conversation** (eye contact, pace, pausing) and **Energy** (vocal tone and facial expression). The goal is to match your delivery to the content.

Some additional delivery considerations come into play in virtual settings. **Verbal delivery becomes more important**, with fewer (or no) visual cues. The following tactics can enhance your message and connection:

- **Vary your pace and tone** using the complexity of your content as guide: slower pace on more complex content; faster on more straightforward points.
- **Pause regularly** and longer than you think is needed. The pauses will allow your audience to digest the content and create space for participation.
- **Use people's names** People perk up when they hear their name mentioned. As you pause for questions, direct them to individuals by using their names.

In addition, **curating your on-camera presence can bolster your non-verbal delivery**. The goal is to make "eye contact" and reinforce your visual impression:

- **Speak directly to the "audience" (aka camera)**
Making eye contact can be challenging on a video call: face the camera and arrange your desktop so that the person/people you're speaking with are close to the camera lens.
- **Consider the camera angle and lighting**
Set up your workspace so that your camera is looking straight at you, with your eyes ~1/3 of the way down from the top of the image. If your audience is looking at your ceiling, the camera is too low. Light sources are best in front of you, evenly lighting your face.

Here are some examples:

Good camera height, even lighting



Camera too low, diffuse lighting



- **Consider your video background**

Check to see what is being captured in the background. Remove extraneous items and any clutter that could be distracting to your audience. While a real background is generally preferable, at times a virtual background will be a better option. If you choose a virtual or blurred background, make sure that pixilation isn't an issue when you move your head or use gestures.

2. Audience & Structure – a message that highlights what your audience cares about and uses explicit structure is more likely to be remembered (HOP-T)

We want to believe an audience remembers everything that we say, but in reality often they either don't remember anything, or they remember random details instead of what really matters. As a communicator, **tapping into what your audience cares about** and **utilizing structure** makes it easier for them to follow, enhancing the likelihood that they will remember your content.

a. Tap into what the audience cares about:

Explicitly identify **who your audience is**, **what you want to accomplish (objective)** and **how you can influence your audience** to achieve that outcome. What do you want your audience to do, think or feel at the end of your communication?

Crafting a message from the audience point-of-view means you need to **take the time to understand what's important to them**. Building from Aristotle, you can then tailor a message that combines **credibility (ethos)**, **emotion (pathos)**, and **logic (logos)**. If you can figure out **what's in it for them (WIIFT)**, then persuasion, or the art of matching your message with what the audience cares about, will naturally follow.

b. Utilize message structure to enhance working memory

After crafting a message that will appeal to your audience, **add explicit structure to increase the likelihood that they remember what you present.** Neuroscience has established that, in the absence of structure, the human brain naturally groups data to make sense of disparate pieces of information. By **using structure, you do the work for the audience** and package the information you want them to remember.

There are two ways to do this: **first, set expectations** for the session and **second, utilize HOP-T** (a framework for presenting visuals) to connect your voiceover with your visuals.

- 1) **To set expectations**, answer, upfront, the audience's questions of Why am I here? What will I do with this information? How can I/should I engage in the meeting?
 - **Introduce who is on the team and build rapport** – The first minute will set the tone for the rest of the presentation. This is a terrific time to engage everyone and build connections with the audience.
 - Make it clear upfront why the audience should care...**why the meeting is important** and **why the audience should listen** to your presentation.

2) Utilize HOP-T to connect your voiceover with your visuals

HOP-T is a framework that creates structure for walking through slides: highlighting the storyline as you move from slide-to-slide and reinforcing the connection between the content on each slide and the main message in the headline.

The four components of HOP-T are:

	Description:	Delivery notes:
H - Headline	The main message of the slide	Can be read or closely paraphrased
O - Orient	Lets the audience know what they're looking at, syncing the visual and verbal together, before the key points	The chart or graphic title is a good starting point. Amount of orientation depends on the complexity of the visual
P - Key Points	Brings the evidence to life, linking back to the main point in the headline. Key Points expand on what the data says & why it matters	Directing the audience to certain components of the visual using navigational language (left, right) and color can be helpful
T - Transition	Connects the current slide with the one that follows, creating a narrative flow	Set up before changing the slide. Use of questions and bridging language can be very effective.

In conclusion, as you prepare for various types of business communications, you can increase the likelihood that your audience will be receptive to your content and remember your message by focusing on two things:

1. Delivery – ensure your delivery is in sync with your message
2. Audience & Structure – highlight what your audience cares about and use HOP-T to connect your voiceover and visuals

By building trust and involving the audience, you have an opportunity to reinforce your message and move your audience toward your overarching objective.

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